# Query Performance Prediction Is Not Benefit Prediction: Observability for Selective Retrieval Interventions

Anonymous Author(s)

## Abstract

Selective retrieval interventions, such as LLM query expansion (QE), cross-encoder reranking, and pseudo-relevance feedback (PRF), are often gated on a query performance predictor: intervene when retrieval looks like it is failing. We show why failure is the wrong target and measure by how much. Writing the decision as maximizing the expected gain of an intervention given the telemetry a system can observe, we decompose an oracle selector's gain exactly into gain on failing queries, the most a perfect failure detector can recover, and gain on healthy queries, which it never sees; with a per-query cost, a third term charges the cost spent on failing queries whose gain does not cover it. On TripClick and BEIR Natural Questions, across eight intervention, corpus, and retriever settings, this failure-only ceiling ranges from 8% to 57% of the oracle's gain, tracking how often an intervention rescues a failing query (1–46%) relative to how often it helps a healthy one; a pre-registered run on an untouched benchmark (ArguAna) gives 18–39%. Detection itself is ordinary QPP (AUC 0.62–0.70, no better than NQC under BM25). It beats predicting harm in seven of eight settings after Holm correction, but largely because failing queries cannot be harmed: on queries the intervention changes, every BM25 gap on TripClick and NQ vanishes, and on ArguAna the gap is not significant for reranking or QE. Budget-matched routing is consistent with this: with the pre-action features and models we test, failure-, NQC-, and benefit-based routing stay close to random routing and far below the oracle; benefit routing beats failure routing only for reranking on NQ. On ArguAna, where every intervention loses on average, failure routing of reranking is worse than random at every budget, and none of three stronger pre-registered benefit predictors (gradient boosting, semantic nearest neighbours, quantile regression) beats it significantly. Telemetry observed after the intervention does better (on TripClick it cuts reranking's loss from −0.028 to −0.001 nDCG@10), but only once its cost is paid.

## 1 Introduction

Retrieval interventions help some queries and harm others. LLM query expansion (QE) can rewrite a query using the evidence it retrieves [13], yet it harms a measurable fraction of queries [1, 23]; cross-encoder reranking and pseudo-relevance feedback (PRF) are equally uneven. The natural response is to intervene selectively, and the natural gate is a query performance predictor (QPP): intervene when the current ranking looks like it is failing [2, 9]. That the gate's target differs from the quantity a policy needs is not new: selective-QE work predicts expansion benefit directly [7], and uplift modelling shows that targeting high-risk cases is not targeting the cases a treatment helps [3, 8]. What is missing is how much a failure gate gives up, why, and whether the telemetry a deployed system can observe, its *observability*, can do better.

**Contributions. (C1)** A decision framing of selective intervention under observable telemetry, with an exact decomposition of the *failure-only ceiling*, including a cost term (Section 3). **(C2)** Its measurement for LLM QE (BM25 and dense retrieval), reranking, and PRF on two corpora: the ceiling ranges from 8% to 57% of the oracle's gain and is explained by rescue and healthy-help rates. **(C3)** Paired, same-query AUCs of detection and action utility (benefit prediction) in all eight settings, Holm-corrected. **(C4)** Budget-matched routing that separates pre-action routing from post-action verification. **(C5)** A pre-registered replication on an untouched benchmark with three stronger benefit predictors.

## 2 Related Work

**QPP and selective QE.** Pre- and post-retrieval QPP (Clarity [6], WIG [26], NQC [18]) predicts query difficulty. Cronen-Townsend et al. [7] decide whether to expand by comparing the clarity of expanded and unexpanded rankings; Amati et al. [2] gate expansion on difficulty predictors; Lv and Zhai [14] predict a per-query feedback weight; Collins-Thompson [5] trades expansion reward against risk. These works evaluate the gated system in aggregate; they neither bound what a failure gate can recover nor compare gates at matched budgets.

**LLM QE and adaptive retrieval.** Query2doc [22], MuGI [25], and CSQE [13] expand unconditionally; generative expansions often hurt strong retrievers [23] and fail on unfamiliar or ambiguous queries [1]. Kotte [10] gates prompt-only rewriting for dense retrievers (gate AUC 0.593, no reliable gain); Adaptive-RAG [9] routes on question complexity and Mallen et al. [15] retrieve only for less popular entities; cascade rankers [21] spend costly stages only on promising candidates. None separates a gate's detection accuracy from its benefit prediction. In uplift terms [8], our setting is unusually clean: both outcomes are observed for every query offline, so the uplift label is exact up to relevance-label noise.

## 3 Framework

For a query $q$, let $R_0$ be the original ranking and $R_a$ the ranking after intervention $a$, with metric $M$ (nDCG@10). The intervention's effect is $\Delta_a(q) = M(R_a, q) - M(R_0, q)$ and its cost $c_a$ ($\Delta_0 = c_0 = 0$). With full information the best decision is $a^*(q) = \arg\max_a\{\Delta_a(q) - \kappa c_a\}$, for a cost weight $\kappa$. A deployed controller sees only telemetry $Z$, so the best it can do is $\pi^*(Z) = \arg\max_a\{\mathbb{E}[\Delta_a \mid Z] - \kappa c_a\}$. What matters is therefore what $Z$ reveals about $\Delta_a$, not about $M(R_0)$. Two information sets differ in cost: *pre-action* telemetry $Z_0$ describes $R_0$ and costs no intervention, though computing it is not free (Section 8); *post-action* telemetry $Z_1$ also describes $R_a$ and exists only after $c_a$ is paid. A failure gate replaces $\mathbb{E}[\Delta_a \mid Z_0]$ with $P(F \mid Z_0)$, where $F = \mathbf{1}[M(R_0, q) = 0]$.

**The failure-only ceiling.** Fix one intervention with $c_a = 1$, so $\kappa$ is its cost per query in nDCG@10 units. The oracle selector earns $G_{\text{orc}}(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[(\Delta - \kappa)_+]$, and a *perfect* failure gate, which intervenes iff $F = 1$, earns $G_F(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[(\Delta - \kappa)F]$. Because $M \geq 0$, a failing

query cannot be harmed ($\Delta \geq 0$ when $F = 1$), and

$$G_{\text{orc}}(\kappa) - G_F(\kappa) = \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[(\Delta - \kappa)_+(1-F)]}_{\text{gain on healthy queries}} + \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[(\kappa - \Delta)_+ F]}_{\text{uncovered cost on failures}} .$$

At $\kappa = 0$ the second term vanishes and the gate's share of the oracle is $\mathbb{E}[\Delta_+ F]/\mathbb{E}[\Delta_+]$. The identity is elementary; its use is that both terms are measurable offline for any intervention. For $\kappa > 0$ it is the exact regret of the policy that intervenes on every failing query (the second term includes failing queries helped by less than $\kappa$), not a ceiling: a detector that also skips such queries can beat that policy. At $\kappa = 0$ it bounds any policy that intervenes only on failing queries; it does not bound a policy built from a failure *score* that also acts on healthy queries.

## 4 Setup

**Data.** TripClick [16]: 1.52M health documents, the TAIL bucket's validation and test splits (1,175 queries each), with click-derived relevance labels. BEIR NQ [11, 19]: 2.68M passages, human labels; 800 validation and a disjoint 2,052-query test set. BEIR ArguAna [20]: 8,674 arguments, 1,406 queries whose relevant document is the counterargument (Section 8).

**Interventions.** *LLM QE*: BM25 over SQLite FTS5 (Porter stemming, title weight tuned on validation); a deterministic rule picks one of four expansion operators or none (1.5%/1.9% of queries under BM25, 10.6%/5.8% dense), and `qwen2.5:3b` (4-bit, greedy, $\leq 2$ calls) writes a corpus-grounded expansion. On TripClick and under dense retrieval (`bge-small-en-v1.5` [24]) the expanded ranking's top candidates are reranked by a MiniLM cross-encoder [17]; the original is not, so those labels include the reranker's effect. TripClick's deployed QE fuses original and expanded rankings (RRF); NQ's uses the expanded ranking. *Reranking*: the cross-encoder scores the BM25 top 100; its top 50 lead, the BM25 order follows. *PRF*: RM3-style [12] weights from the top $d$ documents select $t$ terms whose BM25 ranking is interpolated with the original (weight $\lambda$); $(d, t, \lambda)$ is tuned on validation over 108 settings ($(20, 10, 0.9)$ TripClick, $(20, 30, 0.6)$ NQ). Reranking and PRF are applied to every BM25 query.

**Labels and models.** *Failure*: $F = 1$ (45% of TripClick and 49% of NQ test queries under BM25). *Harmed*: $\Delta < 0$, ties not harmed. Detection is a logistic regression on 8 pre-action features (score shape, term coverage, rare-term IDF, entity overlap, coherence, perturbation stability; 6 under dense). Action utility is fit on $\Delta$ from post-action features (for LLM QE: changes in margin, coverage, coherence, rewrite drift, reranker agreement, overlap; linear under BM25, a logistic harm model under dense; for reranking and PRF: the 8 pre-action features plus overlap, top-1 change, rank-biased overlap, and the new ranking's score shape). For pre-action routing, a *benefit* model regresses $\Delta$ on the 8 pre-action features alone. Every model and threshold is fit on validation and scored once on test; intervals are paired bootstraps over queries ($10^4$ resamples).

**Evidence ledger.** Only the ArguAna results (Section 8) are independent confirmation: every NQ query and the TripClick TAIL test set have been inspected. *Fixed before a test run*: the NQ BM25 and dense runs, and the reranking and PRF runs, each under a written scope. *Pre-committed analyses of already-inspected traces*: the AUCs and policies (Sections 6 and 7), the reranker-matched relabelling, and all of Section 5, budget routing, and Holm correction, which recombine frozen traces without new runs. *Exploratory*: TripClick test was used during development (an early verifier was calibrated and two apparatus defects were found on it), and the changed-query columns of Table 2 were added after seeing the main results. Pre-commitments and scripts are in the anonymized repository: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/agentic-query-expansion-8939/.

**Table 1: Failure-only ceiling (test). Rescue: $P(\Delta > 0 \mid F)$. Healthy helped / harmed: $P(\Delta \gtrless 0 \mid \neg F)$. Share: perfect failure gate's gain over the oracle's at $\kappa = 0$, 95% CI. ArguAna: pre-registered, untouched test ($n = 430$).**

| Setting | $P(F)$ | Rescue | Healthy help | harm | Share |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LLM QE, TripClick | .45 | .07 | .15 | .19 | 42% [32, 52] |
| LLM QE, NQ | .49 | .07 | .19 | .33 | 33% [26, 40] |
| LLM QE, TripClick, dense | .59 | .06 | .25 | .41 | 34% [25, 43] |
| LLM QE, NQ, dense | .26 | .15 | .19 | .29 | 33% [27, 40] |
| Reranking, TripClick | .45 | .17 | .24 | .56 | 52% [44, 60] |
| Reranking, NQ | .49 | .46 | .55 | .19 | 57% [54, 60] |
| PRF, TripClick | .45 | .01 | .12 | .20 | 8% [1, 17] |
| PRF, NQ | .49 | .05 | .20 | .22 | 32% [25, 39] |
| Reranking, ArguAna | .21 | .36 | .25 | .53 | 38% [27, 49] |
| PRF, ArguAna | .21 | .01 | .05 | .06 | 18% [0, 52] |
| LLM QE, ArguAna | .21 | .27 | .23 | .59 | 39% [27, 52] |

## 5 The Failure-Only Ceiling

A perfect failure detector would capture between 8% and 57% of the oracle's gain (Table 1; 18–39% on ArguAna), even though, by the identity, it never makes a query worse. The share follows how often an intervention rescues a failing query relative to how often it helps a healthy one. Reranking rescues often (17% and 46% of failing queries, against 24% and 55% of healthy ones helped), so half its headroom lies in failing queries. LLM QE rescues 6–15% of failing queries and helps 15–25% of healthy ones (a third to two-fifths). PRF on TripClick almost never rescues (0.8%, against 12%), so nearly all its headroom is in healthy queries. The rest of the oracle's gain sits in healthy queries that the same intervention also harms often (19–56%), which is why separating them needs a benefit prediction rather than a failure one.

Costs widen the gap. At $\kappa = 0.02$ nDCG@10 per intervention, the second term (uncovered cost on failures) reaches 0.004–0.011, and intervening on every failing query loses for PRF on both corpora and for dense TripClick QE ($-0.008$, $-0.001$, $-0.002$), while the oracle keeps 0.011, 0.025, and 0.027. At $\kappa > 0$ this is the regret of that one policy, not a ceiling: skipping failing queries the intervention would not help enough could do better, but needs information beyond the binary failure label.

## 6 Detection vs. Action Utility

**Detection is ordinary QPP.** Detection AUC is 0.62–0.70. NQC over the top-100 BM25 scores [18] matches our detector on TripClick (0.647 vs. 0.649) and beats it on NQ (0.721 vs. 0.680); WIG [26] is weaker. The relevant-document count alone predicts failure at only 0.570 and 0.521, and the detector stays significant within count strata.

**Detection beats harm prediction, structurally.** Detection beats harm AUC in seven of eight settings after Holm correction

**Table 2: Detection vs. action-utility AUC on the same test queries (LLM QE: acted-upon queries; reranking, PRF: all). Harm, Helped: action-utility AUC for harmed-vs.-rest and helped-vs.-rest. Diff.: paired bootstrap of detection minus harm AUC (95% CI); † not significant after Holm correction over the eight; ‡ over the three pre-registered ArguAna tests (helped AUC not pre-registered there). Last column: detection minus direction (helped vs. harmed) on queries the intervention changed ($\Delta \neq 0$; exploratory, but pre-registered as secondary for ArguAna).**

| Intervention | Corpus | Retriever | $n$ | Detection | Harm | Diff. | Helped | Diff., $\Delta \neq 0$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LLM QE | TripClick | BM25 | 1157 | 0.643 | 0.552 | +0.091 [+0.045, +0.136] | 0.540 | −0.044 [−0.127, +0.039] |
| LLM QE | NQ | BM25 | 2013 | 0.675 | 0.556 | +0.119 [+0.076, +0.162] | 0.599 | −0.041 [−0.122, +0.036] |
| LLM QE | TripClick | dense | 1050 | 0.621 | 0.599 | +0.022 [−0.028, +0.072]† | 0.464 | +0.043 [−0.063, +0.145] |
| LLM QE | NQ | dense | 1932 | 0.695 | 0.611 | +0.084 [+0.045, +0.123] | 0.406 | +0.122 [+0.047, +0.197] |
| Reranking | TripClick | BM25 | 1175 | 0.649 | 0.575 | +0.075 [+0.029, +0.119] | 0.513 | +0.012 [−0.066, +0.089] |
| Reranking | NQ | BM25 | 2052 | 0.680 | 0.514 | +0.166 [+0.120, +0.213] | 0.679 | −0.025 [−0.079, +0.027] |
| PRF | TripClick | BM25 | 1175 | 0.649 | 0.572 | +0.077 [+0.014, +0.140] | 0.393 | +0.001 [−0.279, +0.433] |
| PRF | NQ | BM25 | 2052 | 0.680 | 0.501 | +0.179 [+0.131, +0.227] | 0.553 | −0.045 [−0.140, +0.048] |
| Reranking | ArguAna | BM25 | 430 | 0.646 | 0.570 | +0.077 [−0.012, +0.162]‡ | – | +0.045 [−0.078, +0.170] |
| PRF | ArguAna | BM25 | 430 | 0.646 | 0.319 | +0.327 [+0.171, +0.466] | – | +0.458 [+0.240, +0.689] |
| LLM QE | ArguAna | BM25 | 425 | 0.641 | 0.609 | +0.032 [−0.052, +0.112]‡ | – | −0.060 [−0.184, +0.064] |

(Table 2). On ArguAna the gap is significant only for PRF, whose 21 harmed queries are ranked below chance, too few to carry the argument; reranking's gap matches TripClick's in size but not significance. On the original settings the gaps persist when harm requires $\Delta < -0.05$ or $-0.10$ in six of eight. They are partly structural: failing queries cannot be harmed and are mostly left unchanged, so the harm label is itself largely a failure indicator. Restricted to queries the intervention changed, on TripClick and NQ detection drops to 0.47–0.58 and every BM25 gap vanishes; only dense NQ keeps one (ArguAna PRF's persists, on 38 queries). Dropping failing queries raises TripClick reranking's harm AUC to 0.659, level with detection. Two controls hold: a harm model on pre- plus post-action features still trails detection (TripClick BM25 +0.040 [+0.003, +0.078], dense NQ +0.070), and relabelling TripClick QE against the reranked original leaves a gap of +0.059 [+0.012, +0.107] (the dense runs stored no reranked original). The action-utility score does rank queries by gain for LLM QE and reranking (best-linear-predictor slopes [4] +0.42 to +1.21, CIs exclude zero) but not for PRF or dense NQ.

## 7 Routing at Matched Budgets

**Pre-action routing.** At every budget, each scorer that decides before intervening stays close to random routing and far below the oracle (Table 3). Failure routing beats random by at most 0.006 at any budget, and falls below it at 75% on TripClick for QE and reranking, up to 50% for PRF on NQ, and at every budget for reranking on ArguAna. Averaged over budgets, NQC is no better than the learned detector (no difference survives Holm), and benefit routing beats failure routing only for reranking on NQ (+0.009 [+0.003, +0.015]), where it leads at every budget. Since all policies coincide at 100%, averaging over 10–75% only (exploratory, chosen after seeing results) widens the differences but leaves the same single Holm survivor (+0.011 [+0.004, +0.019]). The benefit model is linear; ArguAna's B1 and B2 (Section 8), fit on NQ validation (exploratory), do no better: neither beats failure routing after Holm for any intervention, and the best recovers 8% of the oracle-minus-failure headroom (reranking, B2, +0.007 [+0.001, +0.013]). This is an empirical property of these features and models, not a bound; richer pre-action signals may do better. For LLM QE, the deployed failure-selective policy (median threshold) halves generator calls and on NQ recovers most of unconditional QE's loss (+0.015 [+0.008, +0.022], residual −0.007 against BM25); on TripClick no QE policy, including a closed-loop agent, differs from BM25 (MDEs 0.007–0.011).

**Post-action verification.** With $Z_1$, a controller can compute the intervention and keep it only if the predicted gain is positive; its compute is 100%. For reranking on TripClick, where reranking every query loses −0.028 [−0.042, −0.013], verification keeps 15% and loses only −0.001 [−0.005, +0.003], while the thresholded failure gate still loses −0.010. On NQ it keeps 94% of reranked results (+0.223 vs. +0.225) and 67% of PRF results (+0.0085 vs. +0.0097). Post-action telemetry carries information about $\Delta_a$ that pre-action telemetry lacks, at the price of paying for every intervention. The stored TripClick arm used for the relabelling predates a reranker-input fix (0.285 vs. 0.287).

## 8 Pre-Registered Replication on ArguAna

To test the conclusions on data never inspected for this work, we pre-registered a run on BEIR ArguAna, a counterargument-retrieval task, before downloading it: hypotheses, a debate-grouped split (701/275/430), the same three interventions (LLM QE as on NQ, without a reranker), three new pre-action benefit predictors, and Holm-corrected primary contrasts. Each query is itself a corpus document, and 108 arguments are cross-listed under two ids; every search drops the query's own and text-identical documents, and duplicates share a split. These fixes, and three primary contrasts adopted from an externally written protocol, were dated amendments made before any label was read (`configs/arguana_precommit.json`). Predictors are fit on training queries, selected on validation, and scored once on test. B1, B3, and the failure router use 10 pre-action features (the 8 above, NQC, query length). B1 is LightGBM regression on $\Delta$ (learning rate 0.035, 180 trees, $\geq 18$ queries per leaf; depth, leaves, and L2 of $(3, 15, 1)$ chosen over $(5, 31, 5)$ by validation MSE). B2 uses the embedding alone: the inverse-distance-weighted mean $\Delta$ of the $k$ nearest training queries by cosine distance between frozen `bge-small-en-v1.5` embeddings ($k = 60$ chosen from $\{5, 15, 30, 60\}$ by validation MSE). B3 is LightGBM quantile regression (depth 3), its quantile from $\{0.1, 0.2, 0.3\}$ by validation pinball loss (0.1 for reranking). That registered rule is unsound,

**Table 3: Pre-action routing: nDCG@10 gain over the original ($\times 10^3$) when a given share of queries is intervened on, for failure (F), benefit (B), and random (R, expected gain) routing; at 100% every policy intervenes on every query. Oracle and B−F: averages over all five budgets (registered), B−F with 95% CI; * significant after Holm over the six settings. ArguAna (registered, Section 8): B is B1.**

| | 10% | | | 25% | | | 50% | | | 75% | | | 100% | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Setting | F | B | R | F | B | R | F | B | R | F | B | R | All | Oracle | B−F (avg.) |
| LLM QE, TripClick | 3.5 | 1.2 | 0.1 | 3.0 | −0.8 | 0.2 | 3.0 | 0.8 | 0.3 | −1.5 | 1.0 | 0.5 | 0.7 | 19.7 | −1.2 [−3.6, +1.4] |
| LLM QE, NQ | 1.2 | 0.8 | −2.2 | −2.2 | −1.2 | −5.4 | −5.9 | −2.8 | −10.8 | −11.6 | −12.6 | −16.3 | −21.7 | 28.4 | +0.6 [−2.0, +2.9] |
| Rerank, TripClick | 0.3 | 0.3 | −2.8 | −3.1 | −0.8 | −6.9 | −10.1 | −8.6 | −13.9 | −24.8 | −19.7 | −20.8 | −27.8 | 40.5 | +1.8 [−3.7, +6.3] |
| Rerank, NQ | 22.1 | 32.6 | 22.5 | 57.6 | 66.9 | 56.3 | 113.5 | 129.2 | 112.5 | 175.1 | 183.7 | 168.8 | 225.1 | 199.5 | +8.8 [+3.3, +15.0]* |
| PRF, TripClick | −0.7 | 0.3 | −0.1 | −0.2 | 0.7 | −0.3 | 0.5 | −0.2 | −0.6 | −0.5 | −1.1 | −0.8 | −1.1 | 9.6 | +0.1 [−1.0, +1.0] |
| PRF, NQ | 0.1 | 0.2 | 1.0 | 1.4 | 1.2 | 2.4 | 3.9 | 5.7 | 4.9 | 7.5 | 7.6 | 7.3 | 9.7 | 24.0 | +0.4 [−1.7, +2.4] |
| Rerank, ArguAna | −14.5 | 3.8 | −7.1 | −18.6 | −4.8 | −17.8 | −37.6 | −14.9 | −35.6 | −61.4 | −39.8 | −53.4 | −71.1 | 52.8 | +15.3 [−0.6, +27.8] |

**Table 4: ArguAna test ($n = 430$): pre-action routing gain over BM25 ($\times 10^3$), averaged over budgets of 10–100% (registered). B1: gradient boosting on $\Delta$; B2: $k$-NN over frozen query embeddings; B3: lower-quantile boosting. Always: intervening on every query (no budget); Rand. is the mean budget times Always.**

| | Always | Fail. | NQC | B1 | B2 | B3 | Rand. | Oracle |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Reranking | −71.1 | −40.7 | −35.3 | −25.4 | −32.2 | −36.3 | −37.0 | 52.8 |
| PRF | −2.4 | −1.2 | −1.1 | −1.1 | −1.3 | −0.4 | −1.2 | 2.4 |
| LLM QE | −162.8 | −87.3 | −91.3 | −80.5 | −79.7 | −84.0 | −84.6 | 9.9 |

since pinball losses at different quantiles are not comparable, so we also report the secondary pre-registered B3, whose quantile is fixed at 0.25.

On ArguAna every intervention loses on average (reranking −0.071 [−0.108, −0.034], LLM QE −0.163), yet the oracle could still gain 0.053 and 0.010 budget-averaged, so the question is purely one of selection. PRF barely acts here (nDCG@10 changes for 9% of queries), and its registered setting scored slightly below BM25 on validation (0.4899 vs. 0.4903), so its rows are uninformative. Pre-action routing again stays near random (Table 4). For reranking, B1 minus failure routing is +0.015 [−0.001, +0.028] (Holm $p = 0.13$), B2 minus failure +0.008 [−0.005, +0.020] ($p = 0.37$), and B3 versus B1 under a budget cap +0.006 [−0.011, +0.023] ($p = 0.52$); the best recovers 16% of the oracle-minus-failure headroom, below the pre-registered 25% bar. Excluding 100% (exploratory), B1 minus failure is +0.019 [−0.001, +0.035]. Per budget, failure routing of reranking is below random at every budget and B1 above it (Table 3); at 10%, 42% of the queries failure routing picks are harmed. A secondary, also pre-registered family (train-plus-validation refit, wider grids, hyperparameters chosen by validation routing gain, B3 at fixed quantile 0.25) agrees: none of nine contrasts survives Holm, and B3 minus failure is +0.011 [−0.003, +0.023] (12% of the headroom). Allowed to abstain, no router beats abstaining on every query. Post-action verification of reranking keeps 10% and gains +0.004 [−0.005, +0.015]. ArguAna is thus a hard, out-of-domain selection problem, not proof that pre-action prediction cannot work; B1's +0.015 may be real but below what 430 queries resolve. Median per-query costs: reranking 1.1 s, PRF 3 ms (a ten-term second search), LLM QE 6.4 s (P95 10.3 s). Pre-action telemetry is not free: the 8 features take 0.32 s, mostly perturbation-stability retrieval (BM25 itself takes 0.46 s on these long queries), and B2's embedding 33 ms. Matched budgets equalize intervention counts, not runtime: for PRF the features cost more than the intervention.

## 9 Discussion and Limitations

Failure prediction is the usual gate, and it targets the wrong quantity. Two kinds of result support this. One is proven: at zero cost, a policy that intervenes only on failing queries is capped by how often the intervention rescues them, a cap that differs nearly sevenfold across interventions. The other is empirical: the pre-action benefit predictors we test, up to gradient boosting and query embeddings, do not reliably recover the rest. The difficulty is not counterfactual missingness, since both outcomes are observed offline, nor the generator alone, since reranking shows the same gaps; a likelier common factor is that pre-action telemetry describes the original ranking, while $\Delta_a$ depends on what the intervention retrieves.

**Limitations.** One small (3B) generator; reranking and PRF only under BM25, with one cross-encoder and one PRF family. Three corpora, one of them (430 test queries) untouched, which leaves the ArguAna contrasts underpowered for differences below about 0.015; under dense retrieval, retriever strength and domain are confounded, and the dense QE labels include the reranker. TripClick's labels are click-derived and sparse. The cost weight $\kappa$ is illustrative; measured latencies are reported for ArguAna only. The TripClick QE benefit model is fit to the unfused validation label, since no fused validation ranking exists. Apart from ArguAna, all analyses reuse inspected test sets; every pre-committed quantity is reported in full in the repository.

## 10 Conclusion

Detecting that retrieval has failed is ordinary QPP, and at zero cost it bounds what a controller acting only on failing queries can gain: 8–57% of an oracle's gain across LLM QE, reranking, and PRF, depending on how often each intervention rescues a failing query. The pre-action benefit predictors we test, including nonlinear, semantic, and conservative ones on an untouched benchmark, do not consistently recover the rest at any budget; post-action telemetry does better, but only after the intervention is paid for. Selective-intervention work should report the failure-only ceiling and per-budget routing alongside any detector's AUC.

## Ethical Considerations

All data (TripClick, BEIR NQ, and BEIR ArguAna) are existing research benchmarks used under their licenses; TripClick is used for non-commercial research, and no model or per-query output fit on it is released. TripClick's click logs are aggregate, de-identified interactions, and we make no attempt to re-identify searchers. No human-subjects data was collected. The generator is a small, locally hosted model used only to rewrite queries within a bounded action space. Our central finding cautions against deploying generative interventions on the strength of a failure detector alone.

## References


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